The Culture of Business, Finance and the Economy

Class 12 – 16 april

Dr. Juan M. del Nido

First semester 2026

Today
Consultants and rhetorical technologies: Microsoft Excel, PowerPoint and the like

Change Matrix

Division	Executive management FTE ought	FTE current	Delta (absolute)	Delta (in %)
Exec OUs	62.00	60.17	1.83	3.0%
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Recap
Consultants: the work of producing

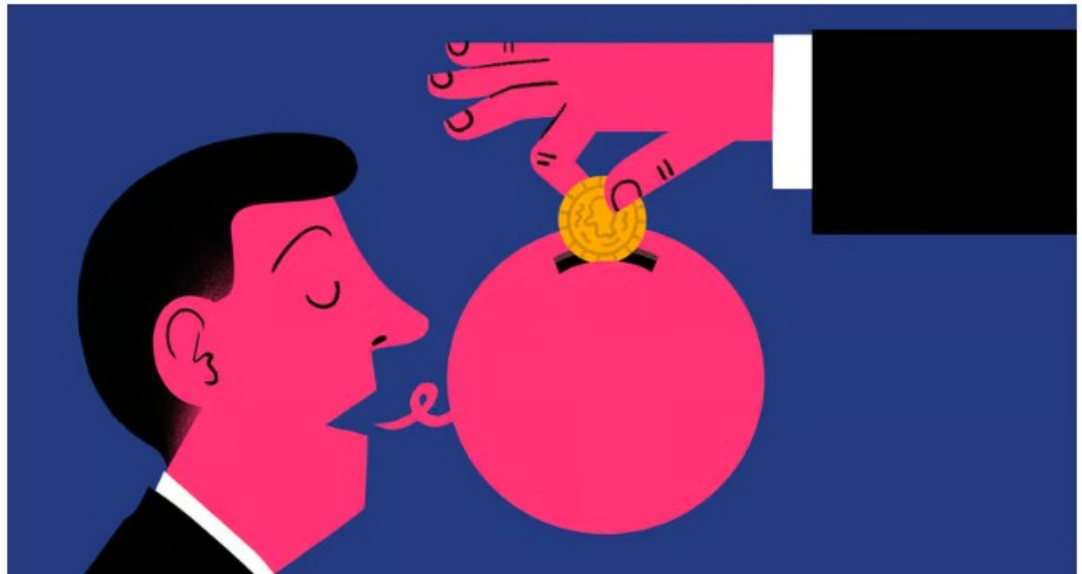
The Economist

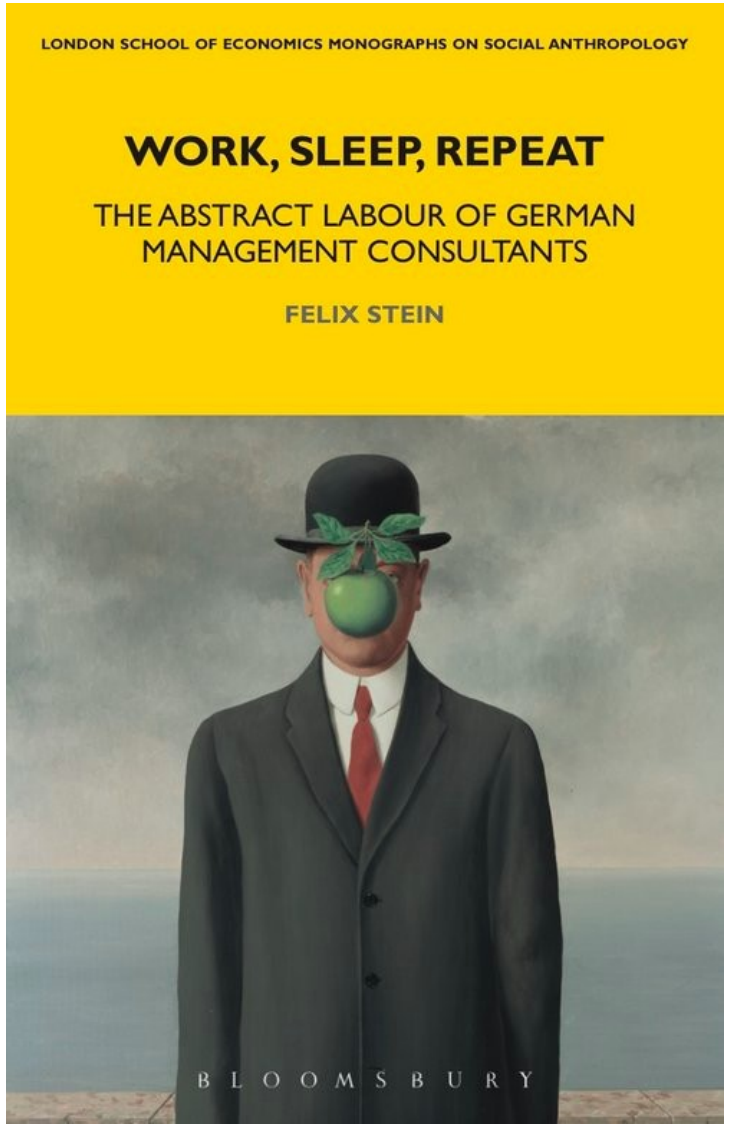
Menu | Weekly edition | The world in brief | Search

Leaders | Consultants under fire

Do McKinsey and other consultants do anything useful?

Though hated, they often provide a valuable service to the economy





Remember, from last class

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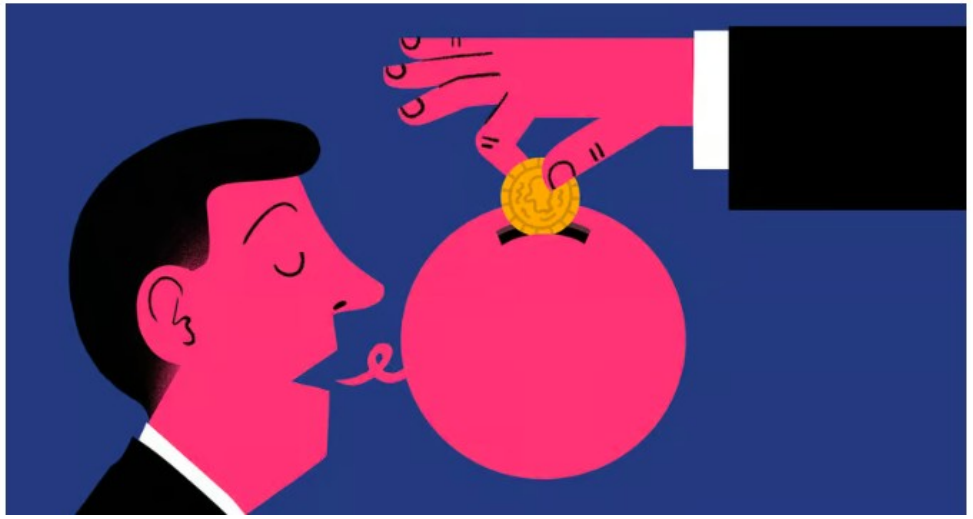


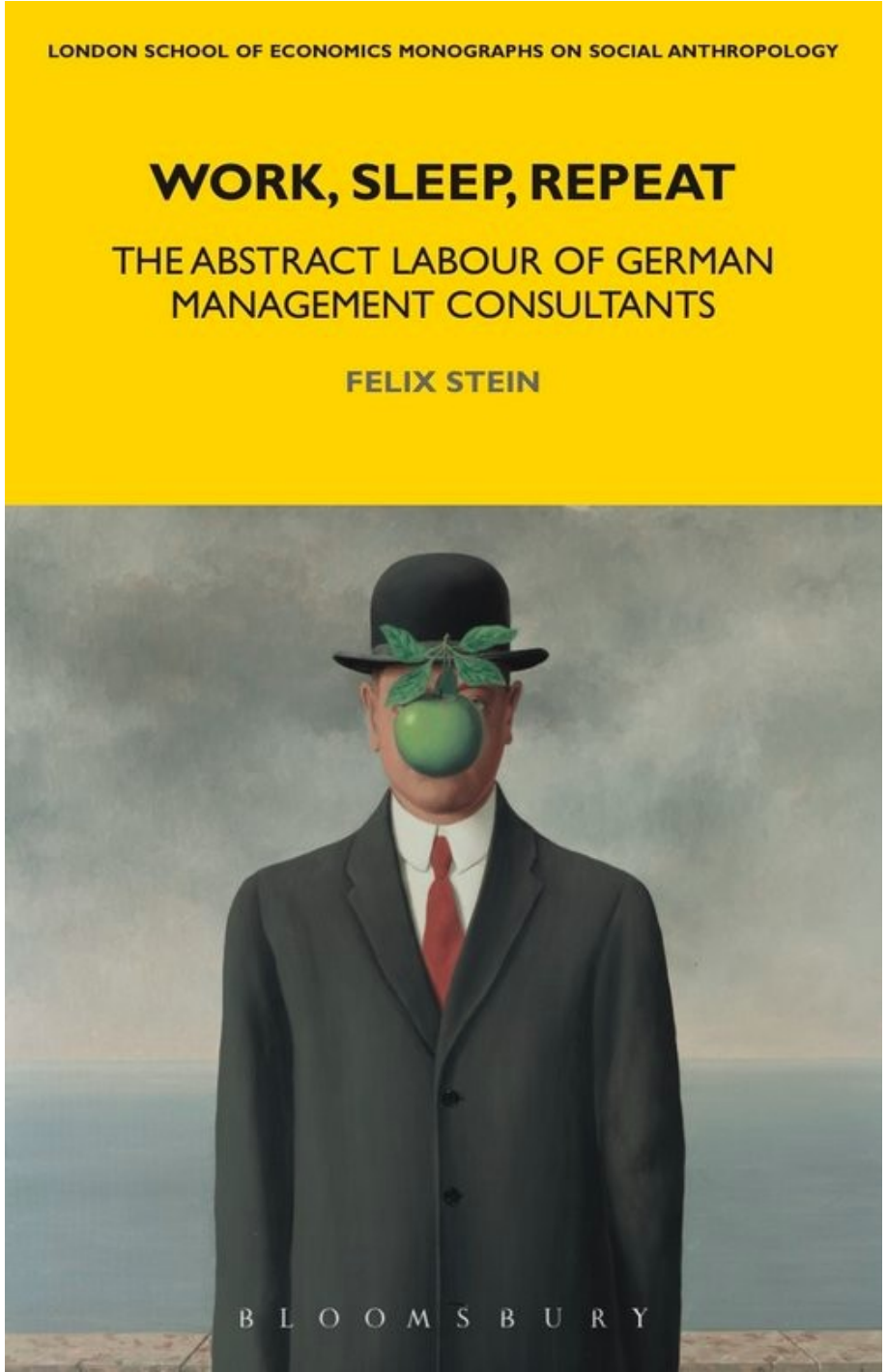
What do these people do? what do they know? deliverables? action?

Rahul, a charismatic middle aged consultant turned software coach, welcomed us thus: 'All that remains after a client has paid millions of dollars for a [consulting] project is a deck [of printed PowerPoint slides], about this big.'

Key

Rhetoric is the ability to see the available means of persuasion in a given situation; in the way they are used, in the way they are designed, Excel, PowerPoint, charts (and their numbers, bullet points, unfalsifiable statements) are rhetorical technologies: they serve to persuade.

Felix !


LONDON SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS MONOGRAPHS ON SOCIAL ANTHROPOLOGY
WORK, SLEEP, REPEAT
THE ABSTRACT LABOUR OF GERMAN MANAGEMENT CONSULTANTS
FELIX STEIN
BLOOMSBURY

We were hired by a German public health insurance company on an ‘organizational project’. These kinds of projects had to do with job cuts.

Management decided to plan future staff levels. They asked all business divisions how many employees they would require. All reported they would require more staff than they currently had. This did not fit the board’s plans for keeping costs down; yet, since none of the division heads would back down, the board decided consultants should deal with the situation.

We met with each division head to find out where they could do with less staff. They all tried to keep their teams as large as possible.

Sofia, my team leader, told me cutting everyone’s number of additional staff to zero, was not an option: some of the divisions genuinely needed more staff, while others could be restructured and would need less.

Sofia built a “Change Matrix” model on Excel, an overview of the entire company, crucial for carrying out our job over the weeks to come.

There is no job without this Excel. Why? Because there is no knowing the entire company without this particular abstraction.

(Remember, from models: thinking with models vs. not thinking without them)

Change Matrix

Division	Executive management				Specialists				Employees				Total				
	FTE ought	FTE current	Delta (absolute)	Delta (in %)	FTE ought	FTE current	Delta (absolute)	Delta (in %)	FTE ought	FTE current	Delta (absolute)	Delta (in %)	FTE ought	FTE current	Delta (absolute)	Delta (in %)	
Exec OUs	**62.00**	**60.17**	**1.83**	**3.0%**	**128.00**	**120.34**	**7.66**	**6.4%**	**362.00**	**361.02**	**0.98**	**0.3%**	**552.00**	**483.19**	**68.81**	**14.2%**	END
Division 1	13.00	12.99	0.01	0.1%	27.00	25.98	1.02	3.9%	78.00	77.94	0.06	0.1%	118.00	103.93	14.07	13.5%	END
Division 2	1.00	1.00		−0.0%	3.00	2.00	1.00	50.0%	6.00	6.00		−0.0%	10.00	8.00	2.00	25.0%	END
Division 3	22.00	21.39	0.61	2.9%	45.00	42.78	2.22	5.2%	129.00	128.34	0.66	0.5%	196.00	171.73	24.27	14.1%	END
Division 4	13.00	12.95	0.05	0.4%	27.00	25.90	1.10	4.2%	78.00	77.70	0.30	0.4%	118.00	103.65	14.35	13.8%	END
Division 5	1.00	0.70	0.30	42.9%	3.00	1.40	1.60	114.3%	4.00	4.20	(0.20)	−4.8%	8.00	5.90	2.10	35.6%	END
Division 6	12.00	11.14	0.86	7.7%	23.00	22.28	0.72	3.2%	67.00	65.84	0.16	0.2%	102.00	89.98	12.02	13.4%	END
Division 7	**77.00**	**76.37**	**0.63**	**0.8%**	**240.00**	**229.11**	**10.89**	**4.8%**	**637.00**	**627.07**	**9.93**	**1.6%**	**954.00**	**856.81**	**97.19**	**11.3%**	END
Leadership	12.00	11.99	0.01	0.1%	32.00	35.97	(3.97)	−11.0%	108.00	107.91	0.09	0.1%	152.00	143.89	8.11	5.6%	END
SD 1	3.00	3.00		−0.0%	10.00	9.00	1.00	11.1%	27.00	27.00		−0.0%	40.00	36.00	4.00	11.1%	END
SD 2	21.00	20.39	0.61	3.0%	64.00	61.17	2.83	4.6%	188.00	183.51	4.49	2.4%	273.00	245.29	27.71	11.3%	END
SD 3	12.00	11.95	0.05	0.4%	40.00	35.85	4.15	11.6%	108.00	107.55	0.45	0.4%	160.00	143.45	16.55	11.5%	END
SD 4	3.00	2.90	0.10	3.4%	10.00	8.70	1.30	14.9%	30.00	26.10	3.90	14.9%	43.00	34.90	8.10	23.2%	END
SD 5	9.00	10.14	(1.14)	−11.2%	34.00	30.42	3.58	11.8%	31.00	31.00		−0.0%	74.00	60.28	13.72	22.8%	END
SD 6	17.00	16.00	1.00	6.3%	50.00	48.00	2.00	4.2%	145.00	144.00	1.00	0.7%	212.00	193.00	19.00	9.8%	END
Division 8	**73.00**	**69.96**	**3.04**	**4.3%**	**143.00**	**139.92**	**3.08**	**2.2%**	**281.00**	**279.84**	**1.16**	**0.4%**	**497.00**	**422.80**	**74.20**	**17.5%**	END
Leadership	10.00	9.00	1.00	11.1%	18.00	18.00	0.00	0.0%	36.00	36.00	0.00	0.0%	64.00	55.00	9.00	16.4%	END
SD 1	18.00	17.27	0.73	4.2%	35.00	34.54	0.46	1.3%	69.00	69.08	−0.08	−0.1%	122.00	104.35	17.65	16.9%	END
SD 2	18.00	17.87	0.13	0.7%	38.00	35.74	2.26	6.3%	71.00	71.48	−0.48	−0.7%	127.00	107.35	19.65	18.3%	END
SD 3	22.00	21.82	0.18	0.8%	44.00	43.64	0.36	0.8%	87.00	87.28	−0.28	−0.3%	153.00	131.10	21.90	16.7%	END
SD 4	5.00	4.00	1.00	25.0%	8.00	8.00	0.00	0.0%	18.00	16.00	2.00	12.5%	31.00	25.00	6.00	24.0%	END
Division 9	**8.00**	**6.30**	**1.70**	**27.0%**	**30.00**	**25.20**	**4.80**	**19.0%**	**51.00**	**50.40**	**0.60**	**1.2%**	**89.00**	**77.30**	**11.70**	**15.1%**	END
Leadership	4.00	3.80	0.2	5.3%	20.00	15.20	4.8	31.6%	31.00	30.40	0.6	2.0%	55.00	45.80	9.2	20.1%	
SD 1	1.00	0.50	0.5	100.0%	2.00	2.00	0.0	0.0%	4.00	4.00	0.0	0.0%	7.00	6.50	0.5	7.7%	END
SD 2	3.00	2.00	1.00	50.0%	8.00	8.00	0.00	0.0%	16.00	16.00	0.00	0.0%	27.00	25.00	2.00	8.0%	END
Division 10	**61.00**	**56.59**	**4.41**	**7.8%**	**118.00**	**113.18**	**4.82**	**4.3%**	**229.00**	**226.36**	**2.64**	**1.2%**	**408.00**	**343.95**	**64.05**	**18.6%**	END
Leadership	18.00	17.27	0.73	4.2%	35.00	34.54	0.46	1.3%	69.00	69.08	−0.08	−0.1%	122.00	104.35	17.65	16.9%	
SD 1	9.00	7.70	1.30	16.9%	20.00	15.40	4.60	29.9%	32.00	30.80	1.20	3.9%	61.00	47.50	13.50	28.4%	END
SD 2	22.00	21.82	0.18	0.8%	43.00	43.64	−0.64	−1.5%	89.00	87.28	1.72	2.0%	154.00	131.10	22.90	17.5%	END
SD 3	7.00	6.70	0.30	4.5%	13.00	13.40	−0.40	−3.0%	27.00	26.80	0.20	0.7%	47.00	40.50	6.50	16.0%	END
SD 4	5.00	3.10	1.9	61.3%	7.00	6.20	0.8	12.9%	12.00	12.40	−0.4	−3.2%	24.00	20.50	3.5	17.1%	END
Company Total	**281.00**	**269.39**	**11.61**	**4.3%**	**659.00**	**627.75**	**31.25**	**5.0%**	**1,560.00**	**1,544.69**	**15.31**	**1.0%**	**2,500.00**	**2,184.05**	**315.95**	**14.5%**	END
END END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END	END

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columns entitled ‘current’ - those who actually existed - and ‘ought’, those that the divisions should have in the future.

In its basic, repetitive structure, Excel made all of its elements essentially similar and similarly knowable. Also, it has a pre-inscribed preference for quantitative data: its full potential unfolds when used to put large amounts of numbers into relation with one another via formulas. This also means Excel was unable to summarize large amounts of qualitative data, which enhanced the abstract quality of this labour.

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These numbers were exact; but were they accurate? More importantly – was their accuracy the point?

This model was a rhetorical technology meant to legitimize our intervention in the company.

The model persuades through its implied holism. It seemingly provided instant access to the entirety of company staff and structure: God’s view through mathematical perfection. This simplified representation of the company was produced without having access to the things, the people, it was supposed to represent. We had not met anyone, we were ignorant of their social relationships, unfamiliar with the material environment of their daily lives, but we were expected to say something meaningful about them.

Sofia asked me to fill it with the data we had received from the company’s divisions. Upon entering everything, I saw numbers did not add up. I would learn with time they almost never do. Either we did not have the right numbers or divisions had not summed theirs up correctly. Our sum-total of all employees in the company also did not match what we had read in internal documents. Worse…

HR, division heads, the board – no one was ever exactly sure:

which numbers corresponded to the employees and their activities,
which employees were currently working,
which ones were not,
who was on maternity leave,
whether maternity leave had been counted half or double or not at all,
when exactly the available input figures had been counted,
who had been added to the workforce since the last count,
how exactly part-timers had been accounted for,
how to deal with people working for multiple departments,
and so on…

Example: Juan at UTDT

not match what we had read in internal documents. It took us numerous calls, emails and *meetings* with controllers and division heads to define what the 'real' numbers were. This kind of work

Meanwhile, some heads of section figured out that if their baseline was large, relative staff increases would look small (thinking in absolute and relative terms). If the baseline was small, even a few additional employees might look like a huge relative increase.

Those who thought that the board was only interested in relative staff increases claimed that their divisions had originally been much larger than assumed.

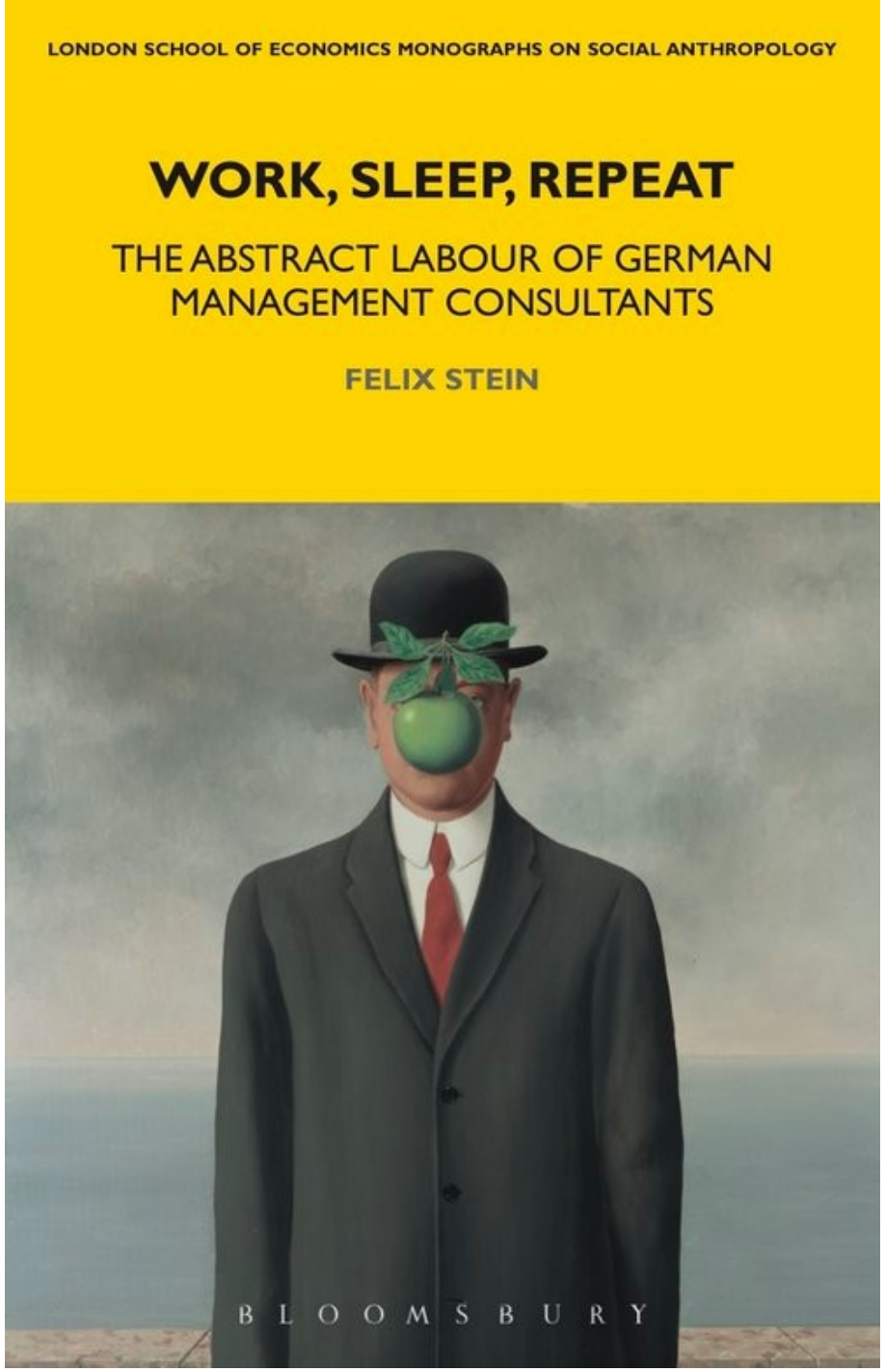
Others, however, thinking in terms of workload, held that their divisions were much smaller than HR assumed, appealing to being understaffed for the work demanded of them.

the basic problem were the abstractions we needed to think with: who knew what hundreds of employees spread out over Germany were *actually* up to at any time?

Lacking concreteness and besieged by competing interests, we agreed to produce a number we would agree on. Not one from our calculations, or an "accurate" number – an *exact* number that did the work of settling expectations and impressions from daily work at the company.

Rhetoric: Back to numbers, ways of knowing… and al-Khwarizmi

Break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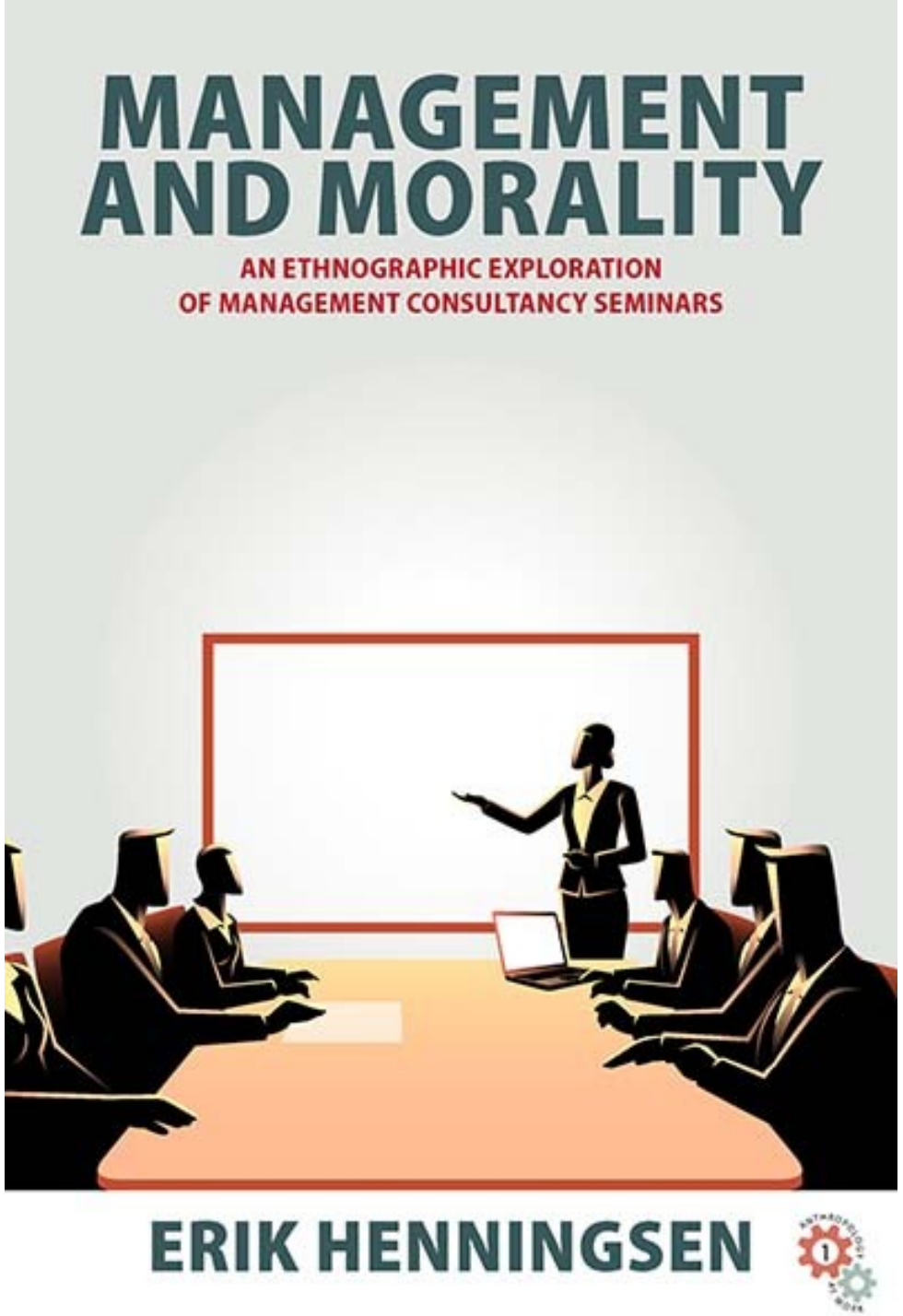

MANAGEMENT AND MORALITY
AN ETHNOGRAPHIC EXPLORATION OF MANAGEMENT CONSULTANCY SEMINARS
ERIK HENNINGSEN

Our final reports were PowerPoint presentations. Even internal reporting was often PPT. We hardly ever used a word processor. Some of my colleagues used writing paper that featured pre-drawn slide templates.

Our use of PowerPoint was a major reason why our work remained considerably opaque.

Why? Isn’t PowerPoint supposed to be clear, concise, logical, quantitative-analysis friendly?

PowerPoint slides should *appear to be* intuitive to the reader. They should elicit an almost automatic reaction – an effect of intuitive understanding. It is hard to overemphasize the importance of aesthetics in this process: all the consultants I knew could spend several hours a day aligning texts, little boxes, lines and arrows, changing bullet point styles and font sizes, using round symbols instead of square ones, enhancing company logos, ensuring high-quality printouts and so on.

The only complexity they allow is mathematical; there is little context as to where this content came from and good consultants know how to direct the attention of the audience towards the graphs and numbers rather than the background stories that would give them meaning and reveal the mess, disagreement and complexities behind producing these abstractions (like we just saw in the Excel example)

Presentations were written along a strict linear narrative structure in which every slide should logically build on the preceding one. Predefined story arcs, such as situation, complication, solution: outline a problem, complicate it, provide a solution.

A common technique was the ‘Mickey Mouse outline’, in which minislides were sketched on one or more paper flip charts. As a result, the flip chart looked somewhat like a comic strip, allowing the consultant to check the flow of a presentation’s narrative and graphics.

slides hilarious. Discussions of company goals came with pictures of a little arrow hitting a target, outstanding questions with a photo of a businessman scratching his head, *next steps* with an image of footprints in the sand and so on. The childishness of these images stood in stark contrast to the presumed importance of our work. The

When there are words they rely on the bullet point as a basic unit of expression. Bullet points are short expressions, often styled in the form of headlines, preceded by a bullet sign (or signs, such as -, . or *) and usually connected to other bullet points in the form of a list.

‘thinking in bullet points’ is a cognitive style that is premised on list-making – rather than narrative or intellectual argument – as its organizing principle, favouring abstraction and buzzwords over detail and nuance.

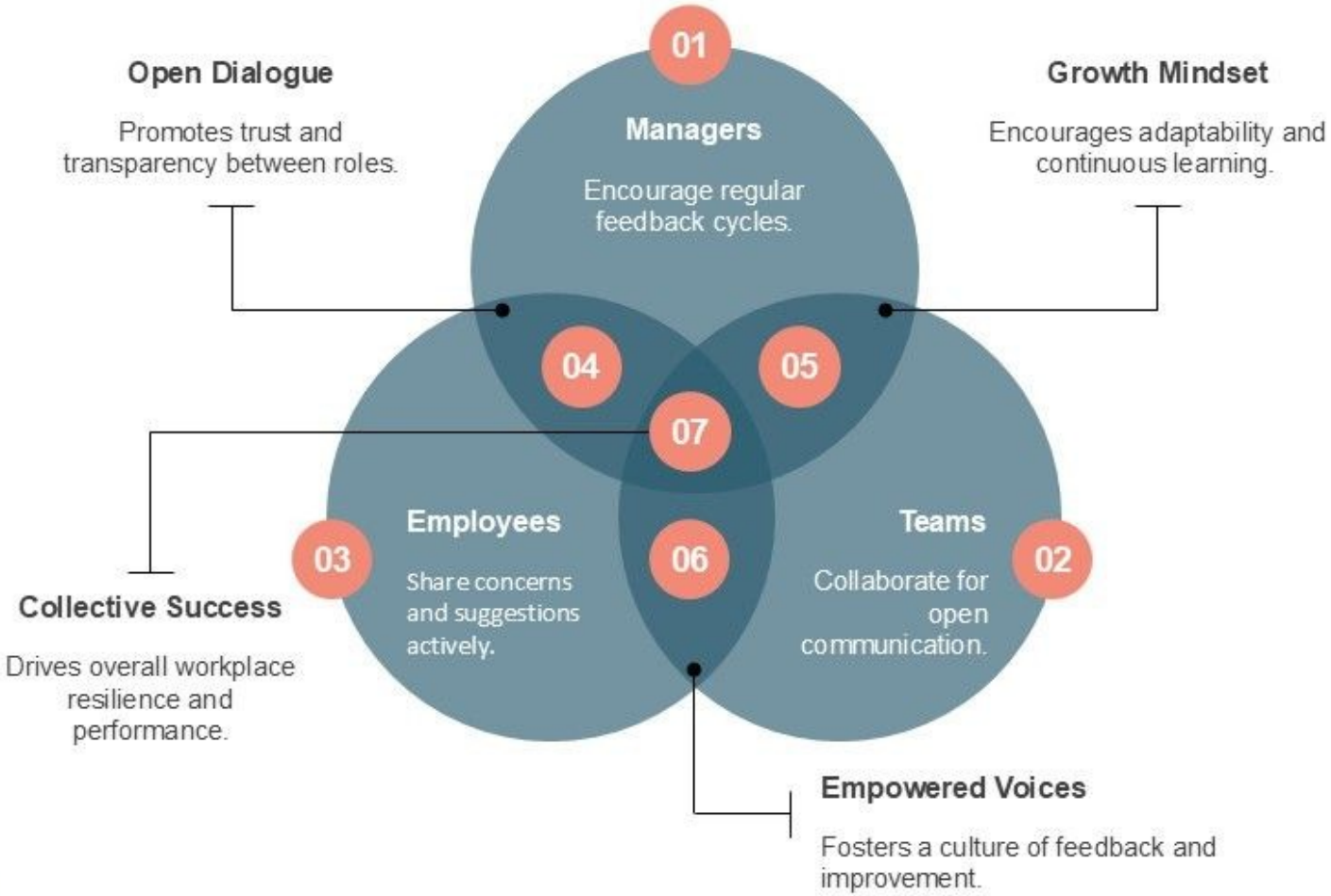
What matters when communicating through bullet points is whether text, usually highly abstract terms, can or cannot be grouped under a thematic heading, not more complicated questions of the logical relations between a series of points or their order of priority in accordance with criteria of truthfulness, normative validity, etc.

Compared to conventional prose, this makes it relatively easy for a group of speakers to come to agreement on a description of the world. It is a language well-suited to an opacity that diffuses disagreement

Examples

8 STEPS TO BUILD PROFESSIONAL RESILIENCE
CHANGE
1
ACCEPT CHANGE
Find ways to become more comfortable with change
2 BECOME A CONTINUOUS LEARNER
Learn new skills, gain new understanding, and apply them in times of change
3
TAKE CHARGE
Take charge of your own career and your own development
4 FIND YOUR SENSE OF PURPOSE
Helps you to assess setbacks within the framework of a broader perspective
8
SKILL SHIFT
Reframe how you see your skills, talents and interests
7
REFLECT
Reflexion fosters learning, new perspectives, and self-awareness
6 CULTIVATE RELATIONSHIPS
Develop and nurture a broad network of personal and professional relationships
5 PAY ATTENTION TO SELF-IDENTITY
Form your identity apart from your job. Stay true to your values
Source : CCL

Utilizing Feedback for Continuous Improvement



Summary Points

01 Increased Engagement

Teams with feedback loops see 15% higher engagement.

02 Reduced Turnover

Regular feedback decreases employee turnover by 30%.

03 Improved Morale

Feedback enhances morale, boosting productivity by 20%.

RESILIENCE IN LEADERSHIP

Tips for Building Resilience as a Leader (Female Infographic)

A Definition of Resilience

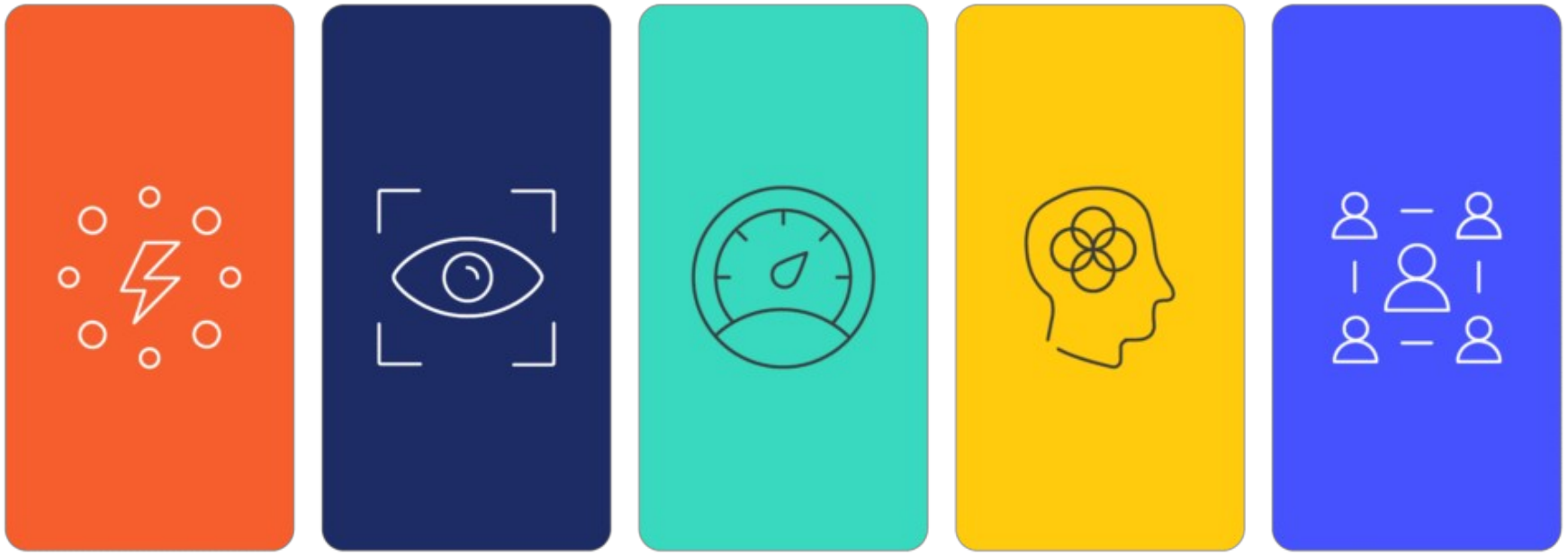
When faced with adversities, it is the ability to:

Endure

Recover

Thrive

The 5 Pillars of Resilience™



ENERGY	FUTURE FOCUS	INNER DRIVE	FLEXIBLE THINKING	STRONG RELATIONSHIPS
HEALTHY CONSUMPTION PHYSICAL ACTIVITY BOUNDARIES SLEEP	PURPOSE PERSONAL CONTROL	MOTIVATION SELF–BELIEF	OPEN–MINDEDNESS POSITIVE FRAMING	BUILDING TRUST ACCESSING SUPPORT

This kind of communication steers away from disagreements on facts and logic in favour of a mutual exchange of statements and tokens of recognition. It ‘liberates’ communication from requirements of logical consistency and of precision in the use of concepts.

It allows us to have entirely diverging understandings of words and concepts (what does “resilience” mean when my job is at stake?) without being disturbed by these contradictions.

KIMBERLY CHONG

BEST PRACTICE

MANAGEMENT CONSULTING *and the* ETHICS *of* FINANCIALIZATION IN CHINA

Pushing the limits
High Performance
Cruising
Business as usual
Achieved with loss of heart
On the run
Good, but not yet great
Sleepy in success
A
A
On Track
Yes, but...
Building momentum
Bumpy ride
Battling it out
In the dark
Flatlining
Struggling under pressure
Unsustainable
Burning platform
Just get on with it
Washed up
Rocky ground
Case for action
Off Track
Downward spiral
Previous Result
Current Result

These descriptions of progress marked specific milestones of organizational change. What did it mean to be at the point of “Just get on with it”?

Liu Xing, the chairman of Systeo China, asked “what does ‘Yes, but’ [progress] mean?” Melissa responded: “[It means] there is engagement, passion, and drive but something is missing… the vision. [Our employees] are not getting what they need: skills, accountability, [they] don’t understand the objectives in the business group. We’re excited, engaged, but… resources are missing to implement change successfully, therefore there is disturbance, fear, distress.”

Conclusion

Excel, PowerPoint and these kinds of charts are rhetorical technologies in that they leverage and activate our ideas about how numbers work, how "objectivity" works, and how ideas travel to persuade and put forward specific projects – for example, job cuts or ensuring "blame" stays at a certain level– in ways that appear entirely commonsensical and beyond debate. These technologies hide the messiness of their workings, of disagreement, of real life behind a sleek, efficient, clean surface.